> intense, vivid gesture. Self-hatred was a necessary component of assimilation, a self-hatred so subtle we never admitted it, even to ourselves, but still it operated as a corrosive poison, setting family members against each other. We reinforced it by keeping distance from those not interested in assimilation—the orthodox, the Yiddish-speaking Jews. We were different from the gentiles, and also different from "those" Jews.[5]

The other consequence of assimilation as a defense against antisemitism is the concept of hidden identity, also called "marranism." "Marrano" as a metaphor, is in fact the principle of Jewish Emancipation: to be Jewish in private and "ordinary" in the street.[6]

The feminist theorist Eve Kosowsky Sedgwick used the terms "closet identity" or "coming out of the closet," terms familiar to homosexuals living in a homophobic society.[7] She gives the example of the biblical Queen Esther as a coming-out model. There is a point at which Esther was to tell her husband, King Ahasuerus, who had just signed a decree for the extermination of the Jews, that she herself was Jewish. Had she chosen not to reveal this, there was no external sign to distinguish this fact. Some have even suggested that the origin of the name "Esther" is derived from "hidden face" (*Hester Panim*).

Some consider this form of disguised identity—this "marranic" silence—in our time as a betrayal; others consider it a justifiable and often necessary self-protection.

The philosopher Jacques Derrida recalled that the first time he heard the word "Jew" was not at home, within his family, but at school in El-Biar, Algeria: "Before understanding any of it, I received this word like a blow, a denunciation, a de-legitimation, prior to any right, prior to any legality."

> My relation to Jewishness was deployed in a necessary silence mode, an "obstinate silence" which protects, or a secret which perhaps keeps one from Judaism, but keeps as well certain a Jewishness in oneself. . . .[8]

Hélène Cixous, a close friend of Derrida, wrote in *Judeities* an essay whose title significantly references Derrida—"A Desire to be a Marrano."[9] Cixous, a famous theoretician of "feminine writing," redefined herself morally and politically as a "Jewoman" (*juifemme*), at the crossroads of several languages and cultures.[10]

Even in the liberal United States, Jews sometimes sought to distance themselves from their Jewishness. Betty Friedan, who grew up in pre–World War II Illinois, remembered:

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